



The NVA in action

In a photograph released by the North on April 28, 1972, North Vietnamese soldiers are seen in action as they fire rockets at ARVN tanks. The location of the photograph was identified as "Dak Can," but the location is probably Tan Canh or Dak To.

Holding Kontum

Kontum lay only 25 miles (40 km) away, but this was a major challenge for the North Vietnamese forces. Their advance forces were in need of supplies, and weeks passed until the NVA was able to mount its assault on the town. By then, the ARVN leadership had sent back one of the airborne brigades and President Thieu had appointed a new corps commander and a fresh leader for the 22nd Division. This officer, Ly Tong Ba, became one of the heroes of the Easter Offensive, holding out against numerous challenges.

General Abrams designated Kontum for a day of B-52 strikes on May 12, just as the North Vietnamese were resuming their attacks. The most serious actions took place on May 14 and May 20. For a time, Kontum had to rely upon aerial supply.

By late May, ARVN forces were able to launch a counterattack. By May 30, the area was sufficiently secure for President Thieu to make a visit. A tragic footnote to the story occurred on June 9, when Vann's helicopter was shot down in the area where he had declared the last NVA positions to be eliminated.